The next day, Arnow called Meiklejohn and told him he planned to show the test to Jack Warner, the mogul who ran Warner Brothers like a feudal monarchy, as soon as Warner could work it into his schedule.

"They'll call you in a few days at the Biltmore," Meiklejohn said.

"I'm sorry, but I won't be there," I said. "I've got to be on a train tomorrow—I've got to get back to my job in Des Moines; the season opener's coming up in a few days and I've got to broadcast the Cubs' games."

Arnow and Meiklejohn wouldn't believe it when I refused to delay my trip back to Iowa. Although I didn't do it consciously, I think it was probably a good strategic move: Hollywood was accustomed to people knocking down its doors for a job; it wasn't used to somebody saying, "Sorry, I've got to go home now."

Still, as soon as I was on the train and America was rolling past me, I said to myself: *What a damn fool you were*.

But less than forty-eight hours after the train pulled into Des Moines I got a telegram:

WARNERS OFFERS CONTRACT SEVEN YEARS STOP ONE YEAR OPTION STOP STARTING $200 A WEEK STOP WHAT SHALL I DO MEIKLEJOHN

I broke the speed records driving down to the Western Union office and wrote out a reply:

SIGN BEFORE THEY CHANGE THEIR MINDS DUTCH REAGAN

Although I broadcast Cubs games for another month, my heart wasn't in it. After a lot of sad good-byes to my friends in Des Moines, I packed everything I owned into a Nash convertible that I'd bought recently for $600 and headed for California.

If those months of rejection after my graduation from Eureka were the low point of my life, that trip across the country, with the top of my car open to the wind and the sun shining on my head, was one of the highest of the highs. I was on my way to Hollywood.